I make this submission on behalf of the Deakin [redacted]. We personally experienced the issues described below and had a significant number of our volunteers speak to us about their experiences of these issues.

Voters attending the Deakin pre-polling centres in Ringwood and Croydon experienced the presence of between ten and seventeen [redacted] Party volunteers across the two weeks of Prepoll. Many of these individuals were identifiable, through their verbal slogans and attire, as members of the Plymouth Brethren. These [redacted] Party volunteers thrust how-to-vote material into voters' faces, requiring voters to effectively "run a gauntlet" to access the polling booth. They congregated at the entrances to the walkways and lined the path from the car park to the outer edge of the six-metre exclusion zone surrounding the polling booth entrance. At times they waited in the car park, directing drivers to car parking spaces, only to thrust a how to vote flyer into their hands as they exited their car and often 'escorted' them to the booth entrance. They were asked by AEC staff to stay out of the car park area, but they desisted only temporarily. On several occasions, at Croydon Prepoll, they followed voters into the exclusion zone and had to be told not to by AEC staff. This conduct was clearly intimidating to some voters, as well as to volunteers representing other political parties and community organisations.

In addition, [redacted] volunteers deliberately positioned themselves flanking the [redacted] candidate on both sides and directly across the walkway to the booth. This positioning impeded voters' ability to approach the candidate and appeared intended to engage him in conversation to prevent interaction with voters. As a result, we found it necessary to assign a volunteer to stand beside the candidate at all times in order to create sufficient space for voters to engage freely.

Several of our volunteers, particularly older women, reported feeling intimidated by [redacted] (Plymouth Brethren) volunteers who stood uncomfortably close or pushed in front of them to access voters. Plymouth Brethren volunteers also made inflammatory comments directed at other volunteers, seemingly to provoke confrontation.

When queues at Ringwood formed—which occurred frequently—[redacted] volunteers positioned themselves so that voters were channelled beneath a [redacted] Party marquee, heavily covered with corflutes, in order to reach the polling booth entrance. At one stage at Croydon, the [redacted] branded marquee was erected across the entrance to the booth so that ALL voters had to walk through it to enter.

The number of corflutes erected by the [redacted] Party was excessive, significantly outnumbering those of all other candidates and community groups combined, including organisations such as Friends of the ABC.

On election day, volunteers at larger polling booths reported similar conduct by [redacted] volunteers. There were also multiple reports of [redacted] Party bunting being placed over the signage of other candidates. In an orchestrated breach of electoral rules a stencil was used to spray paint "Vote 1 [redacted] on footpaths leading to several polling booths. These incidents were reported to the Australian Electoral Commission at booths early in the day; however, no remedial action was taken. (See photos below)

In another obvious breach, [redacted] volunteers set up speakers playing pro [redacted] songs close to the polling booth entrance at both Ringwood and Croydon booths. These songs could clearly be heard within the 6m exclusion zone.

Experiences in Deakin were similar to those reported in other electorates, as described in the reports linked here.

[redacted]

We recommend that the Victorian State Government's regulations be adopted for Federal elections, including a ban on bunting and a limit of two corflutes per party at polling booths, both during pre-polling and on election day. We further recommend the introduction of limits on the number of volunteers per party at polling locations, as much of the intimidating behaviour observed was enabled by the unusually large number of [redacted] volunteers present. Stronger powers for AEC staff at polling booths to act on breaches immediately, without needing to refer to higher level staff, are also required. AEC staff should be able to order volunteers who are blatantly and repeatedly breaking electoral rules to leave the site not return.

[redacted]